

Question 16 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Evaluate whether HRD should be treated as a strategic function rather than only as an employee training activity.

Answer

Evaluation supports treating HRD as strategic. Training is necessary but insufficient.

- 1. Limited view of training:** Training is one mechanism, usually short-term and job-specific. HRD also includes potential, career, climate, OD and culture.
- 2. Strategic contribution:** Capability, leadership pipelines and learning agility are sources of competitive advantage—strategic issues.
- 3. Alignment need:** Without strategy linkage, training may be popular yet irrelevant (activity without impact).
- 4. Evidence from evolution:** Organisations that remain at ‘calendar training’ fail to handle change; those that integrate HRD with strategy adapt better.
- 5. Counter-argument:** Some firms see HRD as a cost centre and prefer buying short courses. This may work for simple skill gaps but not for culture or leadership.
- 6. Risk of over-claiming:** Calling HRD ‘strategic’ without metrics or CEO support is empty. Strategy status must be earned through diagnosis and results.
- 7. Balanced evaluation:** Training remains a core tool; the evaluation is not to abolish training but to nest it inside a strategic HRD system.
- 8. Conclusion of evaluation:** Yes—HRD should be a strategic function, with training as one subsystem, because people capability determines long-term organisational success.

Conclusion. Therefore HRD must be positioned and resourced as a strategic function, while retaining excellence in training as one of its instruments.